



Colleges Face Widespread Closures. So Why Are They Still Resisting Change?

Transformation is no longer optional.



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he state of higher education today could be summed up by a line from *Hamlet*: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies but in battalions.”

The litany of challenges is, by now, familiar. Demographers have sounded the alarm on shrinking high-school graduating classes, a particularly acute problem in the Midwest and Northeast. Middle-skill industries themselves are providing specialized training, with new academic competition from corporations and cultural agencies in the form of short-term credentials. Layered on top of all that is federal and state disinvestment and rising costs. Already about one college is closing or merging [every week](#). We project that about 20 to 25 percent of institutions will merge or close within the next several years.

Public attitudes toward academe indicate that colleges are too costly and out of touch with the workplace. [In a recent NBC News survey](#), only a third of respondents agreed that a four-year college degree is “worth the cost because people have a better chance to get a good job and earn more money over their lifetime.”

Public regional universities and community colleges, particularly those in rural areas, are especially at risk. But the fact is that no college is so exceptional that it will be magically passed over by the challenges facing the sector. Furthermore, only a subset of the wealthiest and most selective colleges and research universities will have the luxury of time — and even that runway has started to crumble amid aggressive federal actions over the past year.

In short, higher education needs to dramatically reinvent itself. It is facing political attacks, changing demographics, and uncertain finances, and the need to change could not be clearer. Despite that, the sector’s desire for change is, by and large, lacking.

On campuses today, discussions about institutional transformation are based on a combination of myth, unfounded viewpoints about key audiences, tunnel vision, and wishful thinking. Faculty members fixate on the many good things that are happening in familiar-to-them programs regardless of whether such success is common across the institution. Faculty members also take concerns over new competitors to be overblown and see new institutional structures as either unproven or dangerous.

Their viewpoints are backed by little data about the needs, tastes, and desires of their students — or those of local employers. Some of this is to be expected: Faculty members have discrete areas of expertise, and those rarely include higher education as an enterprise. To work in a specialized unit of a large organization with expert knowledge of that unit is not the same as knowing the entire organization. And yet when we visit colleges, we've seen not only denial from the faculty but also governance failures, misaligned incentives, and a lack of strategic focus.

One widespread problem is that colleges know how to add, but they can't subtract. Rather than redesign for a new era, the institutional changes we see are often piecemeal and additive — the operational equivalent of a Rube Goldberg machine. Each small change adds complexity but doesn't help the college become more relevant to the workplace or adapt to technological changes to meet the moment.

Although the media often reports news of major cuts at colleges and universities, between 2002 and 2022, the nation's colleges [actually added](#) around 23,000 new academic programs. Addition without subtraction often means institutions are maintaining weak and outdated programs. On top of that, they are incurring the added expense of unproven new initiatives.

Only a small minority of institutions have embraced significant cuts, and most have done so only as a last resort due to the unpopularity and unfavorable optics. In many of these cases, making cuts stemmed the bleeding but was not a long-term solution.

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But not all change is so short-sighted. Workable models are emerging around the country, and with them evidence that institutions can adapt and can navigate faculty resistance, political pressure, accreditation, and financial constraint.

Some of the most visible examples come from research universities and national networks of community colleges. Let's consider a handful of them.

Amarillo College, in Texas, is — like most community colleges — pressured to produce increasing numbers of graduates on tight budgets. It stands out in how it uses data and in becoming a national model of a student-centered institution. The college explored how it was serving its archetypal student: Maria, a 26-year-old single Latina mother who worked two jobs, attended Amarillo part-time, and was the first member of her family to go to college. The result: Like hundreds of community colleges involved in institutional-wide transformation, Amarillo introduced scores of changes over time, including revamping its basic-skills program; introducing wraparound services to address all of Maria's nonacademic needs; and adding internships, apprenticeships, and partnerships with businesses to help students like her better prepare for their careers.

Arizona State University has reinvented the comprehensive research university to serve a diverse population and advance research that is valuable to the public. It's proof that a university can grow while maintaining excellence and delivering quality research, teaching, and service that support the economic growth, overall health, and culture of the communities the university serves. ASU is enrolling super-sized classes and has [its sights set](#) on reaching an online enrollment of 200,000 in the coming years — all while helping a diverse student population graduate at higher percentages than they do at peer institutions. And unlike many colleges, ASU has rallied faculty to participate in its transformation by offering them incentives. They have eliminated weak programs and established dozens of transdisciplinary units along with a panoply of institutes and centers concerned with global challenges and the future. ASU was the first university to [partner](#) with OpenAI to test applications of generative AI and discover how it can support academic transformation.

Elgin Community College, in Illinois, had seen its enrollment decline, but at the end of the pandemic it decided to expand dual enrollment. Elgin's enrollment grew by 33 percent

from 2020 to 2025 and reached its highest headcount since 2014. In 2019, 349 local high-school students enrolled. Four years later, over 1,500 of them did so, and the total number of credits they took increased by over 250 percent.

Northeastern University has been extending its campus and scope across the globe, and it now has campuses in around a dozen cities that help boost the university's scholarly and research capacity. Along with dozens of new institutes, the new campuses operate like enterprise zones free from the restrictions of long, arduous governance deliberation. The university's experiential learning lab and center on experiential AI are also seeking to push the boundaries of experiential education well beyond current practice.

Lewis and Clark Community College, just north of St. Louis, offers another example of successful, audacious change. Recognizing that full-time enrollment was declining steadily (from just over 4,000 students in 2014 to around 2,500 in 2020), the college's president believed that competency-based education (CBE) could help draw more students, enhance student engagement, increase retention, reduce cost to students, and improve student career prospects. College leaders and faculty members visited campuses that had tried CBE, and the college experimented with CBE pilots staffed by volunteers. The college developed faculty champions and resources for both students and faculty. After a few years, dozens of faculty members have supported the initiative and roughly 40 courses have been converted to CBE in fields like welding, criminal justice, English, math, early-childhood education, and speech.

Another model for audacious change is not to change the academic core, but to create innovative enclaves as distinct centers for change at the periphery of the institutions. Southern New Hampshire University expanded its modest online program with the goal of supplementing the enrollments on its traditional campus. The University of Central Oklahoma wanted to boost enrollment and retention rates, so it established a center to improve educational engagement.

These efforts at reinvention have been operating in plain sight for years. The particulars differ, but the pattern is consistent: focused leadership, a clear picture of the institution's realities, a coalition of the willing, and a cadence of pilots that become practice.

What needs to happen next is straightforward, if not simple. Campuses need a new dialogue — one that includes faculty, staff, students, and trustees and is grounded in facts rather than folklore about finances, demographics, and competition. Trustees and senior leaders must encourage new directions for the institution, including substitutions to programs instead of just additions. Presidents should have a durable conversation with faculty about the future, recognizing that faculty are not the problem, and that in most successful efforts, faculty help lead the way.

Every institution is (or should be) an expert on itself — its culture, brand, students, and communities. Supported by the right external and internal data, the expertise of faculty and staff can empower institutions to reconsider what they do, evaluate emerging models, or even blaze their own trails in ways that fit their mission and market.

We have seen such change delivered firsthand. At Brandeis University, where Arthur is currently president, 88 percent of faculty members approved of a comprehensive realignment of the liberal arts to meet the demands of a new century. That work included a reimagining of the structure of the university's academic schools to bring together theoretical inquiry and applied learning, and to more intentionally connect the liberal arts with professional programs. The revision of the core curriculum focused on the knowledge, skills, and values students need in a global and digital knowledge economy, and included a broader rethinking of how learning is defined and assessed across the university. The change included new approaches to documenting student learning wherever it occurs, including competency-based microcredentials and a second transcript that captures applied and experiential learning alongside traditional coursework.

As successful institutions have already found, all it takes is a coalition of the willing to start building momentum for transformative change. That momentum can help institutions put the needs of students, stakeholders, and communities at the center of all they do.

This essay is adapted from [From Upheaval to Action: What Works in Changing Higher Ed](#) (Johns Hopkins University Press).